religion but also to caste. The after-effects of such an approach to indigenous social structures are being felt even today in our understanding of the idea of caste and the way it has been portrayed in India studies within Bharat and the rest of the world. A similar approach to army recruitment based on ethnicity was employed in British Borneo, Burma and the British areas of Africa. The Dutch were no different in their recruitment strategies in the Dutch East Indies.

Apart from the army, this policy of recruitment was extended to civil services as well wherein native elites, who had bought into the idea of the European Way being the pinnacle of civilisation, were given preferential access to European education so that they could occupy posts of ‘prestige’ in the colonial administrative structure. Those that converted to Christianity clearly enjoyed greater representation in the colonial administration, such as in the case of the Christian Sinhalese in British Ceylon. Further, communities and groups were pitted against one another through preferential treatment which created animosities. Similarly, on the economic front, stereotypes relating to occupational specialisations were reinforced and made further rigid through colonial policies, thereby interfering with the organic flow of the native society’s sociocultural dynamics.

The political structure established by the Christian European coloniser in the colonies not only furthered the goal of economic exploitation but also served to consciously keep the native society in a constantly fragmented state while consolidating the European’s political and territorial hold over it. This strategy ensured that for a long time native voices would not unite to oppose the coloniser’s presence; instead they would entirely depend on the coloniser, his ideas and his institutions for continuity of life. The extent of dependence was evidenced by the fact that even the native elites, or perhaps especially the elites, began to subscribe to the coloniser’s view that the native society would fall into disarray and utter confusion if the coloniser were to pack his bags and leave. In the mind of the native, the success of the coloniser in keeping the native society under his thumb was attributed to his overall cultural superiority (race included) and specifically, to the most visible aspect of the colonial apparatus, namely the administrative and legal systems imposed on the colonised societies. Naturally, the political and legal theories underlying the edifice found significant purchase among native elites, thanks to their participation in the colonial administration as